

# Set Up Your Own **PBX** System

Asterisk is one of the first open source PBX software packages that runs on a wide variety of operating systems, including Windows, Linux, Mac OS X, OpenBSD, FreeBSD and Sun Solaris. It was created by Mark Spencer in 1999, who later formed a company named Digium, which is currently one of the leading providers of open source solutions in the telecom space.



Asterisk can run on inexpensive, off-the-shelf hardware, and it includes high-end features such as interactive voice response, voice mail, conference calling, and automatic call distribution and routing, all of which were earlier available only on proprietary PBXs. It can be used to make or take calls either with the public switched telephone network (PSTN) or the Voice over Internet Protocol (VoIP).

It lets us build PBXs with the kinds of features that otherwise would cost thousands of dollars. With Asterisk, the source code is in the users' hands and it can be customised as required. It can do things that normal IP PBXs simply can't. Asterisk was published under the GPL,

making it exceedingly flexible and allowing all users to view and change the source code to adapt the PBX to their own needs. New functions can be created by writing scripts in Asterisk's language, by writing modules in C, and by writing scripts in Perl or other languages. This is one of the reasons for Asterisk's popularity in such a short period of time. The development cycle of Asterisk is faster as it is a community-based project.

## Why the Asterisk PBX?

### Cuts telephony costs

When you compare the basic traditional PBX with Asterisk,